

Encounter over Sierra Madre

“The M-151”

During the month of August 1997, a resident living in Sierra Madre California was startled to hear an extremely loud, continuous, low pitched noise. The witness immediately went outside, and was shocked to see a very large military aircraft flying directly overhead. Coincidentally, the local postman (who was in the area at the time), also saw the aircraft, and was joined by the original witness, who mentioned specifically that the sighting took place at “exactly 12:00 noon”. The witnesses indicated that the aircraft was at an altitude of between 2000-3000 feet, and that it was clear that the craft was “in distress”, and “barely cleared the mountains”. The aircraft was obviously returning from an operational/training mission from over the Pacific Ocean, and needed to make an emergency landing at Edwards AFB.

The aircraft was described as being “matte black” in color, and approximately 300 feet in length. A very long rounded/cylindrical forward fuselage section was observed, which terminated into a triangular or delta wing configuration further back on the aircraft, which was described as looking like a “very long tube connected to a Dorito”. No forward canards were seen on the craft, but a distinct 30 degree angle “drooping nose” was visible, somewhat reminiscent of the French SST concord, or the 1960’s era North American XB-70. This drooping nose feature allowed pilots a less obstructed view of the runway on approach to landing.

Another observer who was a friend and acquaintance of the original witness, also saw the large aircraft pass overhead, and was located approximately one mile west from the Sierra Madre witness. This secondary vantage point provided the witness with a slight side view/angle, and described seeing winglets at the extreme end of the craft’s wingtips. This witness also stressed that the forward fuselage of the craft was abnormally long, and immediately raised the thought “is that ours”. This secondary observer also stressed that the craft was “not going to make it over the mountain tops”, and it looked as though a crash with the approaching terrain was inevitable. Both witnesses described the craft as “huge” in size, and traveling abnormally slow towards the mountains.

Two white colored chase aircraft were flanked on either side of the larger craft, and were believed to be USAF F-15’s, (or possibly US NAVY F-14 Tomcats) which the witness described as “looking like toys” in relation to the larger Mother-ship. Each F-15/F-14 chase aircraft was positioned where the long fuselage joins the beginning of the delta wing. The jet noise of the smaller chase aircraft (and the immediate surrounding area) was easily “drowned out” by the larger M-151. The #2 witness described seeing the chase aircraft fly below the wing of the larger aircraft as though it was examining the M-151 for any signs of damage or visible fuel leaks. The chase aircraft pilot’s made sure they never flew near the rear of the larger aircraft (possibly to avoid the M-151’s “jet-wash”)

No parasitic aircraft was seen on the upper portion of the “Mother-ship”, possibly due to the underside viewing angle, or that the smaller reconnaissance aircraft had already been launched over the Pacific. The witnesses described no visible “contrail”, but indicated that the craft was “ripping the sky”, and left a clear transparent wave pattern/disturbance behind, possibly due to the excess heat from the exhaust. The original witnesses specifically used the word “Monster” to describe the aircraft, and made a point to call Edwards AFB, to inquire about the sighting. Edwards AFB Public Affairs office confirmed that the aircraft in question needed to make an emergency landing, but provided no additional details.